

1. Explain how the city-soul analogy works in the Republic.

In book 2, after finishing his debate with Glaucon and Adeimantus, Plato begins his argument to find the just person... and immediately deviates away to creating Kallipolis! But Socrates has a reason to go through Kallipolis first before the just person: around 369a, he states that “there will be more justice in the larger thing [city] and it will be easier to discern.” Socrates shows throughout the *Republic* that both the soul and the city are just when each part/class plays their proper role and that reason/philosophy is in control.

Kallipolis has three classes: the Guardians (gold), the Auxiliaries (silver), and the Money-makers (bronze). According to Plato, each class has an important job, despite the Money-making class's worse philosophic standards: the Guardians preside, the Auxiliaries protect, and the Money-makers produce. No class is explicitly in control or more powerful, although the Guardians are thought of having the “most important” role.

Socrates brings a very similar analogy to the soul, also divided into three parts: the Rational part, the Spirited part, and the Appetitive part. Again, each part of the soul has an important job (rational thought, courage/determination and allied with the Rational part, and desires—both needs and wants.) Each part of the soul has a different size and behavior, with the Rational being like a little man, the Spirited being like a lion, and the Appetitive being like the Hydra! Similarly to Kallipolis, no part is in control, but the Rational part has the most important role. By this point, it's not very hard to see where the dots connect: each class in the just city corresponds to each part of a just soul, and therefore the just city directly corresponds to the just soul.

Plato builds on this further by using the four Virtues of either a just soul or a Philosopher King of Kallipolis: wisdom, courage, temperance, justice. A wise soul/city has the Rational part leading the whole operation. A courageous soul/city has the Spirited part knowing what to fear and what to ignore, keeping the Appetitive part at bay. A temperate soul/city acknowledges the existence of the Appetitive part, but in the end chooses the Rational part over its own desires. A just soul/city is where each of the three parts are doing their job, “where ruling and being ruled [keeping things in order] are concerned.” All four of these create the ideally just and happy city (or soul), according to Socrates.

Finally, in Book 8, Plato introduces one more analogy comparing the just city to the just man (soul): the scale of constitutions. It begins with the best and most just constitution (way of running a city or a soul), the Aristocracy, which is essentially Kallipolis and Plato’s soul. Next, taking a step down the ladder, is Timocracy, in which the Spirited part of the soul (or the Auxiliaries) is in charge instead of the Rational part, and honor is more valued than wisdom. Another step down leads to Oligarchy, in which the Appetitive part of the soul (or the Moneymakers) is in charge, and profit/personal benefit is valued most for a certain few. The Oligarchy also creates a chaotic split between two cities: the rich and the poor, both fighting for power among the Moneymaking class. Falling even further into chaos is Democracy, in which no class is the ruling party, desires are constantly changing, and citizens have excessive freedom to satisfy their own self interests instead of the common good. And at the very bottom is Tyranny, where the Tyrant as mentioned in Book 9 takes over and nobody is just or happy, not even the tyrant himself. Plato also explains that each of these constitutions

have a corresponding “Man” with certain beliefs and actions associated with him, further strengthening the city-soul analogy.

2. What, in Plato’s view as presented in the *Republic*, is wrong with democracy and why are true philosophers unable to flourish there? What role do the Sophists play in Plato’s assessment of democracy?

Especially in book 8, and throughout the *Republic*, Plato gives arguments to why democracy- tyranny aside- is the worst constitution possible for a just city. Democracy equally prioritizes philosophically unequal opinions, prevents true philosophers from ever being able to spread their ideas, and encourages people like the Sophists to control public opinion and gain power.

Democracy values freedom- according to Plato, too much freedom. The democratic person is constantly changing desires/professions, never allowing them to focus on rationality and the just. Additionally, democracy allows ideas from other cities to sneak in and become a new part of the culture, preventing a clean-slate Kallipolis from ever existing. Democracy claims that all of these ideas are treated equally in government, which can cause chaotic disorganization and mismanagement in a city hoping to be just.

The Democratic government also makes it impossible for philosophers to become rulers. As Plato says at 489b3, “the best among the philosophers are useless to the masses.” Philosophers will never be able to rule via elected means because the masses will vote for who they like- or at best, who they genuinely think is best in

government. Neither of these people would ever be philosophers, because the masses see them as “cranky,” “bad,” and “useless” (Begins at 487b) Unless some great philosopher coup occurs (which would technically be a nice version of Tyranny, according to Plato), philosophers will always live on the sidelines, never able to share their wisdom and good judgment with the rest of the city as democracy promises.

So, who will win the elections if not philosophers? The Sophists! Democracy prioritizes the people who can persuade instead of seeking the truth. Sophists are skilled at winning arguments and getting the public to follow them, but fail to create a good or harmonious society because they are selfish, rather than just.

For the Sophists to be able to consistently win elections, they must believe in public opinion and appease the masses. Therefore, whatever horrible ideas were inserted into the public through too much freedom are now reflected in the leaders themselves. This creates an endless feedback loop of the rulers being manipulated by the public and not holding strong to their own beliefs, eventually devolving into Thrasymachus’s Tyranny. Even without Tyranny, the government becomes subject to poor reason and manipulation- a horrible recipe for a just city.

However, Democracy is still frequently subject to Tyranny, because there is no higher authority holding back the masses from allowing a Tyrant straight into the government or ruling class. The Tyrant himself is also a Sophist, but in an even worse way. Tyrants promise to be the protector of the people, before devolving into a gnarly creature as Socrates describes at 565e2 using the image of the temple of the Lycaean Zeus in Arcadia. By this point, not even the Sophists themselves have a say in rule, and that is why Socrates says democracy is one step away from tyranny: it creates the

perfect conditions for a Tyrant to rise, but currently still has a ruling party (just not the one Socrates wants for a just city).

Overall, Socrates provides many reasons in the *Republic* for why democracy is horrible, including excessive freedom, Sophists taking over philosopher kings, and always being just a step away from tyranny. Clearly, (pure) Democracy cannot form a productive, just, and even luxurious society, and that is why Plato insists on the control and management found in the Aristocracy of Kallipolis.

3. If you were on a curriculum committee at a brand new school, how would you justify making the Republic required reading? Or, take the opposite stance and argue for banishing the Republic from the program.

The *Republic* is an important book from the past that still has its lessons resonating within us today. Therefore, it should definitely be taught at schools for all of its benefits- including an in-depth understanding of ancient and modern society, how to structure the soul, and how to achieve justice and balance in our lives. However, it does contain controversial, opinionated, and hard to read material, so it should be left optional- only for students who want to read the *Republic*.

Plato discusses the ideal city and the different constitutions, allowing the reader to reflect on and understand better the society we live in today. Student readers can use Plato's critiques of democracy, tyranny, and his definition of what makes a city just to compare and analyze the government systems that manage and affect their lives.

Additionally, the Allegory of the Cave makes student readers question the places they get information from, like social media, news, etc. The Allegory of the Cave shows that these are merely shadows, and that experience is one step closer to the Form of understanding. Today, we are immersed in shadows every single day, from shorts and advertisements to even paintings and peer pressure. The *Republic* encourages students to step away from the shadows (at least sometimes), walk out of the cave, and see the light of experience and reality to capture the ideal forms of knowledge.

The city-soul analogy is one of the key lessons from the *Republic*. Students will learn how to be just by balancing the rational, spirited, and appetitive parts of their minds (souls, in Plato's context). They will learn that the soul is analogous to the city, and that if they know how to properly run a city (Kallipolis), then they can become a just person.

However, Plato's views are very controversial, praising the removal of freedom and ignoring human nature that constantly corrupts a pure city or soul. Plato explains that censoring what poems and ideas enter Kallipolis is key for justice, which many today would disagree with. Furthermore, families, marriage, and children are completely split apart by the class system. A class on the *Republic* would encourage students to debate and argue for or against the ideas from the book, expanding their perspectives and establishing what is morally right in our society.

Some students, though, won't be able to keep up. The *Republic* is a very complex book, and some students are not ready for the tone and language use as well as the abstract concepts and their applications. Plato's controversial ideas can build

discussion, but they can also make reading the *Republic* too difficult and overwhelming for certain students.

Because of this, a class on the *Republic* would be entirely optional, but a key component of the curriculum. That way, students who are ready to learn more about Greek philosophy can, and students who aren't ready for the *Republic's* controversy and complexity don't have to overwhelm their minds with a book they aren't ready for.

The *Republic* is one of the most impactful philosophic books ever made, and it definitely deserves to be taught at schools for its important life and societal lessons. However, it should not be required because of its controversial and complicated analysis of ancient Greek society.